

SYNCHRONIZED TSUNAMIS

written by

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-- REALITY --

FADE IN:

EXT. MOORPARK, CA -- STRIP MALL PARKING LOT -- LATE AFTERNOON

Heat shimmer off asphalt. A dented HYUNDAI ELANTRA idles between a vape shop and a Poké Bowl place that is somehow also a notary.

Behind the wheel: GARY PONS, 41, a man whose face suggests he was once described as "promising." A phone is suction-cupped to his windshield. It CHIRPS.

INSERT -- PHONE SCREEN: a gig app called "DASHR." A new order slides in. \$6.75. 11.2 miles.

Gary looks at it the way you look at a bill.

GARY
(flat, to no one)
Six seventy-five.

He accepts it.

On the passenger seat: a spiral NOTEBOOK, cover soft with age. He glances at it. Doesn't touch it. Puts the car in reverse.

INT. GARY'S CAR -- MOVING -- CONTINUOUS

The 118 to the 23 to the 101. Ventura County rolls by: dry hills, strawberry fields, an outlet mall with a Ferris wheel nobody rides.

Gary drives with one hand and holds the notebook open against the wheel with the other, which is illegal and also sad.

INSERT -- NOTEBOOK PAGE: a graveyard of crossed-out loglines in ballpoint:

"A HITMAN WHO ONLY KILLS OTHER HITMEN" -- crossed out,
annotated: "this is john wick"

"WHAT IF THE OCEAN, BUT ANGRY" -- crossed out, annotated:
"what does this mean. what did I mean"

"UNTITLED DAD THING" -- crossed out. No annotation.
Somehow the saddest one.

Gary closes the notebook. Puts it face-down on the seat
like it said something rude.

EXT. CAMARILLO -- FAST FOOD DRIVE-THRU -- LATER

Gary retrieves a bag from a pickup window. The BAG is
enormous. The DRIVE-THRU WORKER, 19, hands it over with
two milkshakes.

DRIVE-THRU WORKER

Two straws?

GARY

It's a delivery.

DRIVE-THRU WORKER

(genuine)

Cool. Two straws?

GARY

...Sure.

EXT. COASTAL COLLEGE CAMPUS -- MAIN DRIVE -- MAGIC HOUR

The Elantra rolls past a sign: CALIFORNIA STATE
UNIVERSITY, ANACAPA SHORES -- EST. 2002. Beyond it, old
Mission Revival buildings, red tile roofs, long arcaded
walkways. Beautiful. Slightly too quiet.

A second, older cornerstone sits near the sign, its bronze
plaque removed. Just four screw holes and a rectangle of
cleaner stone. Gary does not notice it. The camera does.

EXT. CAMPUS DORM -- LOADING ZONE -- CONTINUOUS

Gary sets the bag on a bench, photographs it for the app. He straightens up, looks around at the arcades, the long shadows, the tile roofs going orange in the light.

Something about the place. He squints at it.

GARY

(half to himself)

Didn't they used to house crazy
people here?

A passing STUDENT with a skateboard slows.

STUDENT

What?

GARY

Nothing. Enjoy your --
(checks phone)
-- forty McNuggets.

The student picks up the bag and leaves. Gary stands there one beat longer than necessary, looking down the longest arcade, where the shadows between the columns are very evenly spaced and very dark.

His phone CHIRPS. He goes.

INT. GAS STATION MINI-MART -- CAMARILLO -- DUSK

Fluorescent light. A COOLER CASE hums. Gary stands before it in the posture of a man at a crossroads.

Behind the glass: pints of ice cream. One brand dominates -- MOOLLAMOOK CREAMERY, a smiling cartoon cow in a life vest. Gary reaches past the reasonable flavors and takes the pint labeled:

INSERT -- PINT: "ROCKY COAST -- fudge boulders, caramel undertow, sea salt swirl." A starburst reads: "NOW EXTRA DAIRY!"

At the register, the CLERK, 60s, scans it without judgment. Then, with judgment:

CLERK

You want a spoon?

GARY

No.

A beat.

GARY (CONT'D)

Yes.

INT. GARY'S CAR -- PARKED -- GAS STATION LOT -- NIGHT

Gary eats the entire pint in real time, compressed. Not with joy. With purpose. The phone CHIRPS. He silences it. CHIRPS again. He turns it face-down.

The spoon scrapes the bottom of the carton. He looks at the empty pint.

GARY

(quiet)

Okay.

A pause. His expression changes by one degree. Some internal weather system shifting.

GARY (CONT'D)

Okay.

INT. GAS STATION / EL POLLO FELIZ COMBO -- BATHROOM -- NIGHT

A single-occupancy bathroom shared by a gas station and a fried chicken franchise, which tells you everything. Buzzing light. A motivational poster of a lighthouse, inexplicably.

Gary sits. We frame him from the chest up, respectful, like a portrait of a Flemish merchant. He is sweating. He is not okay.

His phone, on the toilet paper dispenser, BUZZES. A ping. Another. He stares at the middle distance.

The FLUORESCENT LIGHT above him hums. The hum deepens. It stops being a light and starts being a DRONE -- low,

tonal, cinematic, the kind of sound that costs money.

Gary's eyes go somewhere else. Somewhere far away.
Somewhere coastal.

The DRONE swells and --

SMASH CUT TO:

-- THE EPIC --

**EXT. PACIFIC OCEAN -- OFF THE VENTURA COAST -- DAWN --
1952**

BLACK WATER. Pre-dawn. A title, small and serious, lower third:

SUPER: "POINT ANYAPAX, CALIFORNIA -- 1952"

The surface of the ocean is perfectly still. Then -- a DOLPHIN breaks the water. Then another. Then dozens, all at once, all in the same instant, in the same direction, silent. Not playing. Moving. Synchronized like a decision.

On the cliff above, silhouetted against the gray, a LINE OF FIGURES stands watching the water. Hospital gowns. Bare feet on wet grass. Eleven of them, evenly spaced, motionless.

Behind them, flashlight beams bounce down the hillside. ORDERLIES, out of breath, in white.

ORDERLY DAVIES (O.S.)

There! By the fence line!

**INT. ST. AUGUSTINE'S STATE HOSPITAL -- INTAKE CORRIDOR --
LATER THAT MORNING**

A long corridor, Mission Revival arches, red tile -- the same arcades we will one day call a college. Gurneys. Echoes. Institutional green paint over old stone.

ORDERLIES escort a soaking-wet PATIENT -- ELIAS TREJO, 30s, calm in a way that unsettles everyone around him --

down the corridor. His gown drips seawater. Nobody has
toweled him off. Nobody wants to touch him.

At the corridor's end: DR. HALVORSEN, 50s, rimless
glasses, a clipboard, the smile of a man who believes
paperwork can hold back the ocean.

DR. HALVORSEN
Mr. Trejo. Third time this month.

ELIAS
They were calling.

DR. HALVORSEN
The voices.

ELIAS
(patient, correcting)
The water.

Halvorsen makes a note. We see the form on the clipboard:

INSERT -- INTAKE FORM: "DIAGNOSIS: PARANOID
SCHIZOPHRENIA." But above it, a second stamp, older,
half-obsured by the new form clipped over it:
"CLASSIFICATION: TYPE III -- CUSTODIAL. DO NOT TRANSFER."

DR. HALVORSEN
And what does the water say,
Elias?

Elias looks up. For the first time, he looks directly into
the lens -- no, at Halvorsen, but the framing puts us in
the chair.

ELIAS
It says it remembers where
everything used to be.

A long beat. Halvorsen's pen has stopped moving.

DR. HALVORSEN
(to the orderlies, briskly)
Ward C. Full restraints tonight.

They wheel Elias away. As the gurney recedes down the corridor, every ceiling light it passes under FLICKERS, once, in sequence -- like the building is counting him.

Halvorsen watches. He takes off his glasses. Cleans them. Puts them back on. It changes nothing about what he saw.

CUT TO:

EXT. CALIFORNIA STATE UNIVERSITY, ANACAPA SHORES -- MAIN DRIVE -- DAY -- PRESENT

SUPER: "PRESENT DAY"

The same corridor arches -- power-washed, retrofitted, hung with banners: "WELCOME DOLPHINS! FALL ORIENTATION." The school mascot, we now understand, is a dolphin. Nobody in this story will ever remark on this.

A campus SHUTTLE BUS pulls in. Students pour out with duffel bags and parents. Last off the bus:

GABRIEL PONS, 41. Same face as our man on the toilet -- but carried differently. Alert. Purposeful. A canvas messenger bag, a laptop, a paper coffee cup from a real place. A man with somewhere to be.

An ORIENTATION LEADER, 20, all lanyard and enthusiasm, checks a tablet.

ORIENTATION LEADER

Pons... Pons... Gabriel?
Transfer, junior standing?

GABRIEL

That's me.

ORIENTATION LEADER

(reading, no judgment)
It says you took some time off.

GABRIEL

Nineteen years.

ORIENTATION LEADER

(bright)

Welcome back to education!

She hands him a folder and a lanyard and is gone. Gabriel stands in the current of eighteen-year-olds flowing around him. He looks up at the arches.

Hold on his face. Something in him recognizes this place, and he doesn't know why, and it bothers him the way a word on the tip of your tongue bothers you.

INT. ANACAPA SHORES -- ORIENTATION HALL -- DAY

A repurposed chapel. Rows of folding chairs. At the podium, DEAN OKAFOR, 50s, elegant, practiced, delivers the speech she has delivered twenty times.

DEAN OKAFOR

-- one of the youngest campuses
in the Cal State system, on one
of the oldest continuously
inhabited coastlines in North
America. The Chumash people
navigated these waters for ten
thousand years before --

Gabriel, seated in the back row, raises his hand. The Dean, mid-sentence, is not used to this. Orientation is not a hand-raising event.

DEAN OKAFOR (CONT'D)

...Yes?

GABRIEL

What was here before the
university?

A pause that is one half-second too long.

DEAN OKAFOR

A state hospital. It closed in
1997. We're very proud of the

adaptive reuse -- several of the buildings are historically protected.

GABRIEL

What kind of hospital?

DEAN OKAFOR

(smiling; the smile does not move her eyes)

Psychiatric. It's all on the website.

She resumes the speech. Gabriel writes something in a small notebook. Two rows ahead of him, a FRESHMAN in a puka shell necklace and a tank top that reads "LAKE HAVASU 2024" raises his hand without waiting to be called on. This is BRAD, 18, and there is nothing remarkable about him at all, which will turn out to be the most frightening thing in this movie.

BRAD

Yeah, quick question. The dolphins out there --

He points, generally, at the ocean.

BRAD (CONT'D)

-- are those, like, protected protected? Like federally? Or is it more of a vibe?

DEAN OKAFOR

Marine mammals are protected under federal law, yes.

BRAD

(nodding slowly, writing this down)

Okay. Okay. And that's -- like, enforced?

Nobody reacts. It's orientation. People ask weird questions. The Dean moves on. Gabriel glances at Brad for exactly one beat, files him under nothing, and looks away. The camera does not look away from Brad quite as quickly.

EXT. CAMPUS -- ARCADE WALKWAY -- DUSK

Gabriel walks the long arcade alone, folder under his arm. Golden light. Long shadows between the columns, very evenly spaced, very dark.

Far ahead, at the end of the arcade, a WOMAN stands facing away from him, motionless, silhouetted against the last of the light. Professional dress. Sensible heels. She is facing the ocean, which is not visible from here.

Gabriel slows.

GABRIEL

Excuse me -- do you know which
building is Delgado Hall?

Nothing. He steps closer.

GABRIEL (CONT'D)

Ma'am?

Closer now, we see: her hair is WET. Slicked to her scalp, dripping steadily onto the tile. It has not rained in four months. A small dark pool spreads from her heels.

Gabriel stops. The DRONE from the bathroom -- the same tone, though we've forgotten where we first heard it -- creeps into the sound design, low.

GABRIEL (CONT'D)

Are you all right?

The woman's head turns. Just the head. Slightly too far. This is PROFESSOR MARY WHEELAN, 55, and her eyes are calm and black and kind, which is worse than menacing.

PROFESSOR WHEELAN

(gently, with a warmth that
does not belong to her)

You came back.

GABRIEL

I'm sorry?

PROFESSOR WHEELAN

The water remembers where
everything used to be.

A single loud KNOCK --

INT. GAS STATION BATHROOM -- CONTINUOUS [REALITY]

INSERT: Gary's hand, white-knuckled on the edge of the sink. The KNOCK comes again -- someone at the bathroom door.

MUFFLED VOICE (O.S.)

(through the door)

Buddy. There's a line.

SMASH CUT BACK TO:

EXT. CAMPUS -- ARCADE WALKWAY -- DUSK [THE EPIC]

-- exactly where we left it, mid-breath, no acknowledgment. Professor Wheelan blinks, and when her eyes open they are ordinary brown, confused, human.

PROFESSOR WHEELAN

(entirely herself now;
embarrassed)

Oh -- I'm so sorry. I completely
lost my train of thought. Delgado
Hall?

She points, pleasantly, at a building. Her hair is dry.
There is no water on the tile.

GABRIEL

(carefully)

...Thank you.

PROFESSOR WHEELAN
Of course. Welcome to Anacapa
Shores.

She walks off, heels clicking normally, a woman on her way
to a faculty meeting. Gabriel stands in the arcade alone.

He looks down at the tile where the pool of water was.
Dry.

Then he crouches. Touches the tile with two fingers.
Brings them to his lips.

GABRIEL
(quiet)
Salt.

He stays crouched there as the last light goes off the
arches, and somewhere out past the bluffs -- faint,
rhythmic, wrong -- the sound of many bodies breaking the
surface of the water at once.

Gabriel looks toward the ocean he cannot see.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

**INT. ANACAPA SHORES -- BROOME LIBRARY -- SPECIAL
COLLECTIONS DESK -- DAY**

A modern glass library grafted onto an old stone building,
the seam between them visible in the wall like a scar.
Behind the Special Collections desk: RUTH VILLASEÑOR, 60s,
reading glasses on a chain, the stillness of a woman who
has outlasted four university presidents.

Gabriel sets a call slip on the desk. She reads it without
picking it up.

RUTH
St. Augustine's State Hospital.
Administrative records, 1948 to
1962.

GABRIEL

Whatever you have.

RUTH

What we have is sealed. Patient
privacy. State of California.

GABRIEL

The patients from 1952 would be
over ninety.

RUTH

The law doesn't care how old they
are.

GABRIEL

I'm not asking for medical files.
Staff rosters. Building plans.
Anything administrative.

Ruth looks at him for the first time. Really looks.
Something ticks over behind her eyes -- recognition, or
the memory of recognition.

RUTH

You're the transfer. The one who
asked the Dean about the hospital
at orientation.

GABRIEL

Word travels.

RUTH

It's a small campus.
(beat)

Built on a smaller one.

She slides the call slip back across the desk, unstamped.

RUTH (CONT'D)

Building plans are in the county
recorder's office in Ventura.
That's public. That's all I can
do for you.

Gabriel takes the slip. As he turns to go, his eye catches
something: on a cart behind Ruth, half-covered by a tarp
-- a WATER-DAMAGED CARDBOARD BOX, its side stenciled: "ST.
A -- WARD C -- DO NOT DESTROY."

Ruth follows his gaze. She reaches over, without hurry,
and pulls the tarp the rest of the way over the box.

RUTH (CONT'D)
Was there anything else?

GABRIEL
No, ma'am.

He goes. Ruth watches him the whole way out.

INT. ANACAPA SHORES -- MARINE SCIENCES LECTURE HALL -- DAY

Two hundred seats, a third full. At the podium, PROFESSOR
ADEYEMI, 40s, the rumpled energy of a man who would rather
be on a boat, clicks through slides of the local
coastline.

PROFESSOR ADEYEMI
-- which makes the Anyapax pod
one of the most studied coastal
populations on the Pacific
seaboard. Roughly two hundred
individuals. Multi-generational.
Some of the matriarchs in this
pod are older than this
university.

SLIDE: aerial photo of dolphins in formation. The
formation is unusually -- geometrically -- regular.

PROFESSOR ADEYEMI (CONT'D)
Now. This photograph was taken
eleven days ago, and I want to be
careful how I say this, because I

am a scientist and not a mystic.
(beat)

We have no model for this
behavior. Two hundred animals
surfacing in synchrony, holding
station in a fixed bearing, for
six hours. Not feeding. Not
traveling. The closest analogue
in the literature is --

He stops. Looks at the slide.

PROFESSOR ADEYEMI (CONT'D)
(quieter)

There is no close analogue in the
literature.

In the back row: Gabriel, taking notes. Three seats over:
BRAD, feet up, phone out. On his screen --

INSERT -- BRAD'S PHONE: Facebook Marketplace. A used
ZODIAC inflatable, \$900 OBO, photographed on a lawn in
Oxnard. Brad types: "will u take 400 cash and a ps5 with
no controllers"

Adeyemi advances the slide: a hydrophone waveform.

PROFESSOR ADEYEMI (CONT'D)
This is the pod's acoustic
signature that same night. Or
rather -- it isn't. Because for
six hours, two hundred dolphins
made no sound at all.

He lets that sit. The hall is quiet.

BRAD
(raising his hand, not
waiting)
So like -- where do they sleep?
Location-wise. Is that mapped?

PROFESSOR ADEYEMI
...The pod shelters in the sea
caves off Punta Gorda in rough

weather. It's in the reading.

BRAD

(typing it into his phone)

Punta. Gorda. Cool cool cool.

Nobody reacts. Gabriel, without knowing why, has stopped writing.

INT. ANACAPA SHORES -- SANTA ROSA DORM -- BRAD'S ROOM -- NIGHT

A double room split down the middle by taste. One side: tidy, surf posters, textbooks. The other side: Brad's. A flag of a cartoon character drinking beer. A gaming chair worth more than the car that brought him here.

Brad is on his bed, phone on speaker, counting a small, sad fold of cash. His roommate KOA, 18, built like a lifeguard, is at his desk trying to study.

CHAD (V.O.)

(through the phone; the
voice of a man in a garage
in Lake Havasu)

Four thousand three hundred,
Bradley. That's where we are. And
every first of the month it does
what?

BRAD

It grows.

CHAD (V.O.)

It grows, Bradley. Like a
beautiful garden.

BRAD

Chad, the boat sank. Boats sink.
That's like -- an act of God,
legally --

CHAD (V.O.)

You drove my WaveRunner into a
dock, Bradley. God was not
operating the WaveRunner.

The call ends. Brad stares at the ceiling. Then he opens
his laptop. A Discord server: "REEF HUSTLERS ☐☐". He
scrolls to a pinned message from a user named ABALONEKING.

INSERT -- DISCORD: "buyer in dubai paying 300/per for
pacific bottlenose teeth. must be clean pulls. no farm
raised lol. DM for logistics. serious ppl only."

Brad reads it. Does math on his fingers. Runs out of
fingers.

BRAD

(to Koa)

How many teeth does a dolphin
have.

KOA

(not looking up)

Why.

BRAD

Ballpark.

KOA

Like eighty? A hundred?

Brad's face goes through several emotions, all of them
financial.

BRAD

(soft; reverent; a man
seeing a way out)

That's a Chad. That's a whole
Chad per dolphin.

KOA

(now looking up)

Why do you need to know how many

--

BRAD

No reason. Marine bio. It's for
marine bio.

Koa looks at him a moment longer, then goes back to his
textbook. Brad opens a new note on his phone and titles
it, in earnest: "BUSINESS PLAN."

EXT. ANACAPA SHORES -- CENTRAL QUAD -- FOUNTAIN -- 3:14 AM

Empty campus. Sprinklers hiss somewhere. The quad fountain
bubbles, lit from below.

Standing IN the fountain, fully clothed, water to his
shins, perfectly still: PROFESSOR ADEYEMI. Facing the sea.
His laptop bag is set neatly on the fountain's edge, as if
he'd stopped to check his email and then walked into the
water instead.

A CAMPUS SECURITY SUV rolls up. OFFICER DIPPOLITO, 30s,
more flashlight than officer, gets out.

OFFICER DIPPOLITO

Professor? Hey -- Professor
Adeyemi. You can't be in the
fountain.

Adeyemi does not move. Dippolito wades a step closer,
shines the light on his face.

His eyes are open, calm, black. Water runs from his
hairline, down his face, far more water than the fountain
spray accounts for.

PROFESSOR ADEYEMI

(a voice with strange
harmonics under it;
unhurried)

Kiy 'alulkoy. Kiy 'alulkoy.

OFFICER DIPPOLITO

Sir, I don't -- is that -- sir,
I'm gonna need you to step out of
the fountain.

Adeyemi turns his head to Dippolito. And smiles. It's a gentle smile. A grandfather's smile.

PROFESSOR ADEYEMI

The boy is counting teeth.

The fountain lights FLICKER -- once, twice -- and every light on the quad flickers with them, in sequence, out toward the sea.

Then Adeyemi blinks, sways -- and it's just a wet, confused man in a fountain at three in the morning.

PROFESSOR ADEYEMI (CONT'D)

(entirely himself;
horrified)

...Why am I in the fountain?

INT. ANACAPA SHORES -- STUDENT UNION -- DAY

Lunch rush. Gabriel eats alone with the county building plans spread across the table. At the next table, a cluster of STUDENTS, thrilled with themselves:

STUDENT #1

-- in the fountain, dude, at three A.M., speaking in tongues --

STUDENT #2

Because this whole place was an insane asylum. That's not even a rumor, my RA said the tunnels are still under the dorms.

STUDENT #1

The ghosts of the patients, bro. They shocked people here. Like electrically.

STUDENT #3

(eating; unbothered)

Then why'd you enroll.

STUDENT #2

In-state tuition.

Gabriel isn't looking at them, but he's stopped chewing. On the building plan in front of him, his finger rests on a structure near the bluff edge labeled: "HYDROTHERAPY ANNEX -- CONNECTS WARD C, SEE SHEET 9."

There is no Sheet 9 in the stack. He checks twice. Sheets 8 and 10 are consecutive, and the page numbers have been re-inked by hand.

EXT. ANACAPA SHORES -- SERVICE ROAD BY THE BLUFFS -- DAY

Gabriel walks the campus perimeter with the plans, orienting himself. Wind off the ocean. Below the bluffs, the water is a hard, flat blue.

Ahead, a groundskeeper's cart. SAM QUINTANA, 50s, sun-lined, unhurried, trims a hedge that does not appear to need trimming. She's positioned, we might notice, exactly where the hedge frames the best view of the water.

GABRIEL

Excuse me. Do you know if there
used to be a building out here? A
hydrotherapy annex?

Sam doesn't stop trimming.

SAM

You're standing on it.

Gabriel looks down. Under the dry grass at his feet: the faint rectilinear ghost of a foundation, the grass over it growing a slightly different green.

GABRIEL

It's not on the current maps.

SAM

Lot of things aren't.

GABRIEL

(carefully)

People are saying the campus is
haunted. The old hospital. The
patients.

Sam stops trimming. She looks at him, then out at the water, then back at him, deciding something about him.

SAM

The buildings aren't haunted.
Buildings can't hold anything.

(beat)

Water can.

She loads her shears into the cart.

GABRIEL

What does that mean?

SAM

It means the patients aren't your
problem. The patients were never
anybody's problem.

(getting in the cart)

You want to understand this
place, stop reading floor plans
and start watching the tide
charts.

She drives off. Gabriel stands on the buried foundation.
Far below, offshore -- a long, silent line of dolphins
surfaces once, all together, and is gone.

INT. ANACAPA SHORES -- RECORDS ANNEX -- NIGHT

An unglamorous 1950s outbuilding behind the library -- the
one part of campus the renovation money never reached.
Gabriel, hood up, works the latch of a ground-floor window
with a library card. It's a bad plan executed adequately.

Inside: rolling shelves. Dust. Decades of boxes. His phone
flashlight finds the stenciling: ST. A -- ADMIN. ST. A --
WARD A. WARD B.

The WARD C shelf is empty. A clean rectangle in the dust
where boxes used to be.

GABRIEL

(under his breath)

Ruth.

His flashlight sweeps on -- and stops on a WALL.
Corkboard, floor to ceiling, and pinned to it, curling
with age: INTAKE PHOTOGRAPHS. Hundreds of them. Black and

white. Men, women, teenagers, in gowns, each holding a slate board with a number.

He moves the light across the faces. They do not look insane. That's the thing you can't unsee once you see it: face after face, they look calm, and tired, and certain.

The light finds one photo, center of the wall. ELIAS TREJO. Slate number 0113. Looking directly into the camera the way he looked into the lens in 1952. Even in a sixty-year-old photograph it lands like eye contact.

Behind Gabriel, unnoticed: the room's dead fluorescent tubes have begun to glow. Faintly. Without power.

A VOICE, close:

SECURITY GUARD (O.S.)

You came back.

Gabriel spins. A SECURITY GUARD stands in the aisle -- no flashlight, no radio chatter, water dripping steadily off the hem of his uniform onto the concrete. Calm, black, kind eyes.

GABRIEL

(backing up a step)

I was -- the window was open, I'm
a student, I --

SECURITY GUARD

(with immense gentleness)

Number one-thirteen kept his
promise. Will you keep yours?

GABRIEL

I don't -- I haven't promised
anything --

The guard tilts his head. On the wall, every intake photograph is now faintly, impossibly, warm to look at, as if lit from behind.

SECURITY GUARD

You will.

The dead fluorescents FLARE to full brightness --

INT. GAS STATION BATHROOM -- CONTINUOUS [REALITY]

BLACK SCREEN for a single frame -- then INSERT: the phone on the toilet paper dispenser lights up and BUZZES, rattling against the metal. On screen: "DASHR: You've been inactive for 94 minutes. Everything OK?"

SMASH CUT BACK TO:

INT. RECORDS ANNEX -- CONTINUOUS [THE EPIC]

The lights are dead again. The aisle is empty. No guard. No water on the concrete.

Gabriel stands alone in the dark, breathing hard, phone flashlight shaking slightly in his hand.

On the corkboard, one photograph has come unpinned and lies face-up on the floor at his feet: Elias, 0113.

Gabriel picks it up. Turns it over. On the back, in pencil, in a careful institutional hand:

INSERT -- PHOTO REVERSE: "TYPE III. RESPONSIVE TO SEAWATER. DO NOT TRANSFER INLAND."

Gabriel reads it three times. He looks up at the wall of faces.

GABRIEL

(a whisper)

Transfer inland from what?

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. VENTURA COUNTY LIBRARY -- MICROFICHE ROOM -- DAY

A basement room the internet forgot. Gabriel at a microfiche reader, the photo of Elias propped against the machine. Pages of the VENTURA COUNTY STAR-FREE PRESS

scroll past in gray light.

He stops on a headline, October 1952:

INSERT -- MICROFICHE: "ELEVEN PATIENTS IN MASS DROWNING
ATTEMPT AT ST. AUGUSTINE'S -- HOSPITAL PRAISES SWIFT
ACTION OF STAFF."

Below it, a photograph: the eleven figures on the cliff at
dawn -- the image from our prologue, but shot from behind,
from the orderlies' position. In the water beyond them,
dozens of small dark shapes breaking the surface.

Gabriel leans in. Zooms. The shapes are dolphins. The
caption reads: "Patients apprehended at cliff's edge."

GABRIEL

(quietly, to the machine)

They weren't jumping.

He scrolls the caption again, then the photo again. Eleven
people standing still, evenly spaced, facing the water.
Dolphins arrayed in the water facing back.

GABRIEL (CONT'D)

They were meeting.

He prints the page. The printer, a beige veteran, takes
its time. While it grinds, Gabriel notices the LIBRARIAN
across the room -- motionless at the window, back to him,
looking in the direction of the sea, which is six miles
away and not visible from a basement.

The printer finishes. The librarian turns around, normal,
pleasant.

LIBRARIAN

Find everything you needed?

GABRIEL

(taking the page; watching
her)

Getting there.

EXT. PUNTA GORDA -- BEACH ACCESS -- NIGHT

A dirt pull-off above a black beach. Brad's Elantra-adjacent sedan is parked crooked. Brad wrestles a KAYAK off the roof, alone, headlamp on, YouTube video playing in his pocket.

YOUTUBE VOICE (V.O.)

(tinny, from his pocket)

-- and remember, guys, open-water paddling at night is extremely dangerous and you should never, ever do it --

BRAD

(skipping ad-style)

Yeah yeah yeah.

Strapped to the kayak's deck: a CROSSBOW, still with a Facebook Marketplace price tag on the stock (\$60), and an empty COOLER with a Vons bag inside it.

He drags it all to the waterline. The ocean is dead calm. Glass. He pauses -- even Brad registers, dimly, that the ocean is never like this.

BRAD (CONT'D)

(to the sea; pleased)

Thank you.

He paddles out. The shore recedes. His headlamp beam skims across black water.

FURTHER OUT -- LATER

Brad drifts, crossbow across his lap, scanning. Nothing. No splash, no fin, no birds. The water around the kayak is so still it holds the stars.

BRAD (CONT'D)

(calling out, softly)

Here, uh... boy?

Nothing. He checks his phone: 2:57 AM. No bars.

The kayak MOVES. Not a wave -- a nudge. From below. Gentle. Deliberate. The bow swings toward shore.

BRAD (CONT'D)

Whoa -- okay --

He paddles against it. The kayak swings back toward shore. He paddles harder. From under the hull: a long, slow, resonant sound -- not a whale song, not anything -- a tone that we recognize, though Brad doesn't, as the DRONE.

Brad stops paddling. Sits very still.

BRAD (CONT'D)

(small)

I'll just -- I can come back
another time.

The nudge comes again, softer now that he's agreed. The kayak glides shoreward, unrowed, dead straight, at the speed of a walking adult. Brad grips the sides and does not move for the entire ride.

EXT. PUNTA GORDA -- BEACH -- DAWN

Brad wakes on the sand above the tide line. He doesn't remember lying down.

He is covered -- neatly, completely, shoulder to ankle -- by a BLANKET OF KELP. Laid over him in overlapping strips. Tucked at the edges.

He sits up slowly. The kayak is beached beside him, parallel to the water, paddle laid across it just so. The crossbow is gone.

Twenty feet out, in the shallows, a single DOLPHIN holds station, upright in the water, watching him. It does not move. It watches him the way you watch a child who has been warned once.

Brad, to his credit as a character and his damnation as a person, takes from this exactly the wrong lesson:

BRAD

(hoarse; wounded)

That was a sixty-dollar crossbow.

**INT. ANACAPA SHORES -- ADMINISTRATION -- CONFERENCE ROOM
-- DAY**

Faculty senate meeting. Twelve professors around a long table. Dean Okafor at the head, mid-agenda.

DEAN OKAFOR

-- which brings us to item four,
the accreditation timeline.
Provost's office has asked --

She stops. Mid-sentence, mid-gesture. Her eyes go calm and black.

With perfect composure, Dean Okafor picks up the water pitcher from the center of the table, walks to the west-facing window, and pours the entire pitcher out onto the floor.

The water spreads across the tile. She crouches and watches it -- watches WHICH WAY IT RUNS -- with the focused attention of a surveyor.

Nobody speaks. Eleven tenured adults sit in silence, because there is no committee procedure for this.

The water runs west. Toward the sea. Dean Okafor nods, once, satisfied, as if a measurement has been confirmed. Then she blinks -- herself again -- and looks down at the pitcher in her hand, the water on the floor.

DEAN OKAFOR (CONT'D)

(a long beat; then, with
total institutional
authority)

Item five.

They move to item five. Under the table, one professor slowly slides her chair an inch away from the window.

**INT. ANACAPA SHORES -- BROOME LIBRARY -- SPECIAL
COLLECTIONS -- DUSK**

Closing time. Ruth shelves ledgers. Gabriel appears at the desk and lays down, side by side: the microfiche printout, the building plan with the missing Sheet 9, and the intake photo of Elias Trejo, back side up. "DO NOT TRANSFER INLAND."

Ruth looks at the items. Then at him. A long silence.

RUTH

You broke into the annex.

GABRIEL

The window was open.

RUTH

It certainly was not.

GABRIEL

(leaning in)

Eleven patients on a cliff in 1952 and the paper calls it a drowning attempt. A hydrotherapy annex that connects to Ward C on a sheet that doesn't exist. A wall of intake photos where nobody -- nobody, Ruth -- looks sick.

(beat)

You moved the Ward C boxes. You knew someone would come looking eventually. I think part of you wanted them to.

Ruth takes off her reading glasses. For a moment she is not an archivist; she is a much younger woman remembering something through a doorway.

RUTH

I was a nurse's aide here. Ninety-four to ninety-seven. The last three years.

(beat)

End of life care, mostly, by then. Old men and women who'd been inside since Eisenhower.

GABRIEL

What were they like?

RUTH

(the answer costs her
something)

Kind. They were kind, and they
were sane, and every one of them
slept better when their bed faced
the water, and worse when it
didn't, and the state of
California kept them behind a
fence for forty years.

(she puts her glasses back
on)

They weren't sick. That's all
I'll say.

She reaches under the desk and sets a KEY CARD on the
counter between them. Old laminate. A faded photo of a
younger Ruth.

RUTH (CONT'D)

Sub-basement of this building
predates this building. The
elevator needs a card that hasn't
worked since the renovation.

(beat)

It works.

Gabriel takes the card.

GABRIEL

Why me?

RUTH

(returning to her shelving;
not looking at him)

Because they've started coming
back, and the last time nobody
understood in time, we put them
in restraints for forty years.

(beat)

And because you're the only
person on this campus asking
questions who isn't eighteen.

INT. BROOME LIBRARY -- SERVICE ELEVATOR / SUB-BASEMENT -- NIGHT

The card reader blinks red -- red -- GREEN. The elevator descends past B. Past B2. To a button labeled only with a worn dot.

The doors open on the old hospital's records vault: a low concrete room, original 1950s shelving, and a smell of paper and brine that has no business being fifty feet above sea level.

Gabriel's flashlight finds the boxes Ruth moved: ST. A -- WARD C. And behind them, older, a locked steel cabinet stenciled: "MEDICAL DIRECTOR -- EYES ONLY."

The lock is a 1950s lock and Gabriel has modern spite. It gives.

Inside: bound ledgers. He opens the first on a reading stand. His flashlight moves down the page and, as it does, everything the audience believes about this movie quietly comes apart:

INSERT -- LEDGER, TYPED, 1954: "MEMORANDUM -- RE: FACILITY COVER DESIGNATION. Sacramento confirms psychiatric designation approved effective fiscal year. All Type I-III residents to receive standard diagnostic paperwork (schizophrenia, paranoid; mania; hysteria) for external inquiries. ACTUAL INTAKE CRITERIA REMAIN UNCHANGED. Under no circumstances are residents to be referred to state psychiatric review, as review would find no basis for commitment."

Gabriel turns the page. Faster now.

INSERT -- LEDGER: "TREATMENT SCHEDULES (COVER): electroconvulsive therapy to be LOGGED but not administered except as required for inspection visits. Sedation logs to be maintained at double actual dosage. Hydrotherapy annex is NOT a treatment facility and is to be logged as one."

Gabriel stops. Reads that last line again. His hand is not steady.

GABRIEL
(barely audible)
It was never a hospital.

He flips to the intake criteria. The flashlight beam trembles on the page:

INSERT -- LEDGER, HANDWRITTEN, EARLIER HAND, 1949:
"Criteria for custodial intake -- Type I: subject demonstrates knowledge of tide, weather, or marine movement not obtainable by ordinary means. Type II: subject demonstrates influence over same. Type III: subject is demonstrably in COMMUNICATION with --"

The page is torn. The sentence ends in a ragged edge.

Dead silence in the vault. Gabriel stands absolutely still, the torn page in his hand, the entire history of the place rearranging itself around him. The single most important, most delicately suspended moment of the film. Hold it. Hold it --

OVER THE HELD SHOT OF GABRIEL IN THE VAULT -- a single, brief, unmistakable FART. Room tone: gas station bathroom. One beat. Then the vault's room tone resumes as if nothing happened.

Gabriel -- who heard nothing, because for him there was nothing -- carefully sets the torn page down and opens the last ledger in the cabinet. The Medical Director's private log. Final entry, 1962, handwritten, hurried:

INSERT -- LOG: "They are not our patients. I have understood this for some time. They are hostages. The question I can no longer avoid is: whose good behavior are we holding them against? -- H."

Gabriel closes the ledger. In the dark of the sub-basement, somewhere behind the walls, water moves through pipes that were decommissioned in 1997.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

EXT. ANACAPA SHORES -- BLUFF TRAIL -- LATE AFTERNOON

Wind. Gabriel walks the bluff trail with the torn ledger page in a plastic sleeve. Ahead, at the trail's end, Sam Quintana sits on the tailgate of her groundskeeping cart, thermos in hand, as if she has been waiting for him since the previous scene. Possibly since 1952.

He hands her the plastic sleeve without a word. She reads the torn intake criteria. She does not seem surprised, which is its own answer.

SAM

Took the state of California
thirteen years to build a fence
and one afternoon to invent a
diagnosis.

GABRIEL

Type III. "In communication with
--"

(beat)

With what, Sam?

Sam caps her thermos. Looks at the water for a long moment. When she speaks, it is plain, unhurried, without a drop of mysticism -- a woman relaying family history.

SAM

My grandmother's people have a
story about how there got to be
dolphins. Long time ago, the
people crossed from the islands
to the mainland on a bridge the
Earth made for them -- a rainbow,
in the telling. And they were
told: don't look down. Some
looked down. They fell.

(beat)

And the ones who made it across
couldn't stand the grief of it,
so it was arranged that the ones
who fell wouldn't drown. They
were changed in the water. They
became the dolphins.

GABRIEL

So the dolphins are --

SAM

Family. Not "like" family.
Family.

(beat)

And family gets looked after.
There have always been people the
water talks to. Every generation,
a few. Watchers. My grandmother
called them the ones the sea
keeps. They kept the peace
between what's on the land and
what's in the water. Ten thousand
years, that worked fine.

She hands the page back.

SAM (CONT'D)

Then in 1948 the state built a
hospital and spent fifty years
collecting every single one of
them behind a fence.

GABRIEL

(the whole shape of it
landing)

They emptied the coast. There's
been no one on watch since --

SAM

Since before you were born. The
water's been calling and nobody's
been picking up.

(beat)

So now it's stopped calling and
started dialing whoever's
closest. Your professors. Your
dean. A security guard. Anybody
standing near the shore with a
body it can borrow.

GABRIEL
The possessions.

SAM
(mild correction)
The shifts. Somebody has to stand
the watch, Gabriel. The sea keeps
who it keeps.

Gabriel looks out at the water. Then, slowly, the
practical horror surfaces:

GABRIEL
Sam -- a watch against what? For
ten thousand years there's a
peace, there's watchers, fine.
But the spirits are active NOW.
This month. Something made the
water put every borrowed body it
has on the wall at the same time.
(beat)
What are they watching?

Sam looks at him. For the first time, she looks tired.

SAM
That's the part I don't know.
Whatever it is --
(nodding at the sea)
-- they consider it an emergency.
And I've never heard of that. Not
in any story. Not once.

OFF GABRIEL -- and we CUT, with terrible comic timing that
no one on screen is aware of, DIRECTLY TO:

INT. OXNARD -- TYLER'S GARAGE -- NIGHT

The emergency. BRAD stands in front of a whiteboard. On
the whiteboard, in marker: a childlike drawing of a
dolphin, a dollar sign, and the words "OPERATION TOOTH
FAIRY."

His audience: TYLER, 19, a large, agreeable young man
eating cereal from the box, and the ZODIAC INFLATABLE from

Facebook Marketplace, now purchased, taking up most of the garage.

BRAD

Phase one. We go out at night.

Phase two --

(tapping the dolphin
drawing)

-- acquisition. Phase three,
we're rich, I pay Chad,
everything goes back to normal.

TYLER

(mouth full)

How do we do phase two?

BRAD

(a man who has prepared for
this question)

Speargun.

TYLER

On a dolphin? Dude, aren't they
smart? Like they have names for
each other. I saw a thing.

BRAD

Tyler. Chad has a name for me.
You know what it is? "Bradley."
Every month, on the first. "It
grows, Bradley."

(beat; quieter, the closest
Brad comes to a soul)

I just want to get back to zero,
man. I'm not even trying to get
ahead. I just want to be a guy
who doesn't owe anybody anything.

A silence. Tyler chews, moved despite himself.

TYLER

...Can I drive the boat?

BRAD
You can drive the boat.

TYLER
(pumping fist, cereal dust)
Yes.

Behind them, unnoticed, the garage's UTILITY SINK faucet has begun, very slowly, to drip. Each drop lands with a sound a half-octave too deep.

INT. ANACAPA SHORES -- GABRIEL'S DORM ROOM -- NIGHT

A spartan single. Gabriel has turned one wall into an investigation board: intake photos, the microfiche print, tide charts, a campus map with pins.

He runs a string from pin to pin -- locations of the possessions: fountain, arcade, records annex, conference room. He checks dates against a printed TIDE CHART, then against something else -- a campus incident log.

GABRIEL
(to himself, working)
Wheelan, the arcade -- night
after the crossbow guy posted in
the marine forum. Adeyemi, the
fountain --

He pulls up a screenshot on his laptop: a Reddit thread, r/VenturaCounty: "some idiot kayaking at Punta Gorda at 3am almost drowned lol, left his cooler."

GABRIEL (CONT'D)
-- same night.

He steps back from the wall. The string, seen whole, isn't a web. It's a PERIMETER. Every possession site, connected, forms a line between the ocean and -- he traces it -- the dorms. Santa Rosa Hall.

The possessed aren't wandering. They're stationed.

GABRIEL (CONT'D)

It's not a haunting. It's a
picket line.

He looks at the center of the perimeter on the map. Santa
Rosa Hall. He grabs his jacket.

INT. SANTA ROSA DORM -- HALLWAY / BRAD'S ROOM -- NIGHT

Gabriel moves down the hall, checking room numbers against
the incident log -- then stops. One door is ajar. Koa's
and Brad's room. Inside, KOA packs a duffel bag, fast,
upset.

GABRIEL

Hey -- sorry -- I'm looking for
the resident of this room. There
was a kayak, at Punta Gorda --

KOA

(not stopping)
Brad. You want Brad.

GABRIEL

Where is he?

KOA

Gone with Tyler and the boat. And
I'm going to my cousin's, because
I am not sleeping in this room
anymore.

GABRIEL

Because of Brad?

KOA

(zipping the bag; turning;
scared in a way big men
rarely let show)
Because for three nights, every
faucet on this floor turns itself
on at 3:14. Because the RA stood
at our door for two hours Tuesday

with his eyes wrong, saying "the
boy is counting teeth."

(beat)

And because Brad bought a
speargun, man. Whatever is
happening on this campus, it is
about my roommate, and I don't
want to be in the splash zone.

He shoulders past. Stops. Comes back -- decency outrunning
fear:

KOA (CONT'D)

Punta Gorda. The sea caves. He
kept saying the pod sleeps there.
If you're gonna do something,
tonight's the night he went.

EXT. PACIFIC OCEAN -- OFF PUNTA GORDA -- NIGHT

Black water. The Zodiac idles, engine low. Tyler at the
tiller. Brad at the bow with the SPEARGUN, headlamp
sweeping the swells. The mouth of a SEA CAVE yawns in the
cliff face, exhaling with each swell.

And this time, the sea does not stop him.

That's the horror of the scene: no nudge, no drone, no
glassy calm. Just ordinary black ocean. The pod is there
-- fins in the headlamp beam, close, unbothered -- and
nothing intervenes, and slowly the audience realizes,
before Brad does, before Gabriel does, what the spirits
have understood all along: they can borrow every body on
that campus, and not one of those bodies can be made to
hurt a person. The watch can warn. The watch can return
crossbows to the sea. The watch cannot stop a boy with a
speargun.

That was never their job. Their job was to be here after.

BRAD

(whispering)

Tyler. Tyler, cut the engine.

The engine dies. Silence. Water against the hull. A young
dolphin -- small, curious, a juvenile -- surfaces ten feet

from the bow and regards Brad with one bright eye.
Brad raises the speargun.

TYLER
(a whisper; the last
conscience in reach)
Brad. Man. It's looking at you.

BRAD
(steading; the whole sad
ledger of his life in his
voice)
Four thousand three hundred
dollars, Tyler.

OFF THE SHOT -- we do not see it. We CUT TO:

EXT. ANACAPA SHORES -- CAMPUS -- CONTINUOUS

-- every light on campus, every window, every streetlamp,
every vending machine, FLICKERING at once, in one long
sequence, out toward the sea.

In the arcade, PROFESSOR WHEELAN stops mid-step.

In the security SUV, the GUARD's eyes go black mid-sip of
coffee.

In her office, late, DEAN OKAFOR rises from her desk
without closing her laptop.

And in his dorm, Gabriel's investigation wall -- every
intake photograph -- flutters once, all together, though
the window is closed.

EXT. PUNTA GORDA -- BEACH -- LATER THAT NIGHT

Gabriel's car slews into the dirt pull-off. He runs down
to the beach --

-- and stops.

Along the waterline, evenly spaced, motionless, facing the
sea: THE POSSESSED. Wheelan. Adeyemi. Okafor. The guard.
The RA. The librarian from Ventura, six miles from her

basement. Eleven of them. The same formation as the cliff in 1952. Water runs from all their hairlines. None of them are wet from the sea.

Beyond them, in the shallows, the pod has gathered -- two hundred dolphins, holding station, silent, facing the beach. Between the two lines, half in the water: the ZODIAC, swamped, abandoned. An empty cooler rocks in the surf.

And on the wet sand, where the two formations face each other, lies the JUVENILE DOLPHIN. Still. A spear through it.

Gabriel walks between the lines of the possessed -- none of them turn -- and kneels by the animal. Puts a hand on it. It is the first time in the film he touches anything from the sea.

GABRIEL

(barely a voice)

I'm sorry. I was slow. I'm sorry.

Silence. Then every possessed head turns to him at once -- not menacing; worse: hopeful -- and they speak together, eleven voices with the harmonics under them, and the voice is gentle:

THE POSSESSED

(in unison)

One-thirteen was slow.

One-thirteen still kept the
watch. Will you?

GABRIEL

(standing; wrecked; angry)

Kept the watch -- WHERE WERE YOU?

You were there! You were on the
water -- you let it happen --

THE POSSESSED

(in unison; and here the
film's heart cracks open)

We may not touch the living. We
could only make it calm. We made

the water calm for the little
one. It was not afraid. It was
never afraid.

A long silence. The surf. Gabriel looks at the dolphin. At
the two hundred waiting in the shallows. At the eleven
borrowed bodies who came to stand on a beach because
standing is all they are permitted.

GABRIEL

(quietly)

And Brad? The one who did this?
What happens to him?

The possessed all turn back to the sea in unison. A pause.
Then, from all of them, very softly:

THE POSSESSED

The water remembers where
everything used to be.

Out past the pod, in the deep channel, something vast
displaces the water -- no shape, no creature, just a long,
wrong SWELL that rolls shoreward, lifts the swamped
Zodiac, and sets it down again. A knock at a door.

The tide, Gabriel notices -- the film makes sure we notice
-- has begun, very slightly, to withdraw.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. ANACAPA SHORES -- DINING COMMONS -- DAY

Lunch. Trays, chatter, normalcy running on fumes. Brad
sits alone eating chicken tenders with the serenity of a
man whose problems are solved. A duffel bag sits on the
chair beside him like a date.

Gabriel sits down across from him, uninvited.

BRAD

(mouth full; friendly)
'Sup. You're the old transfer
guy.

GABRIEL
You went out to the caves last
night.

BRAD
(instant, smooth)
Nope.

GABRIEL
Your boat is on the beach, Brad.
Your roommate moved out. There is
a dead animal on the sand with a
spear in it that traces to a
Discord server where you asked,
in writing, under your own
gamertag, how to "de-tooth" --

BRAD
(leaning in; whispering;
genuinely aggrieved)
Okay -- volume -- that is a
private business channel.

GABRIEL
(low; even; a father's
voice, the one thing Gary
knows cold)
Listen to me. I have spent a
month learning what this
coastline is. There are things
standing watch on this campus
that have been standing watch for
ten thousand years, and last
night you put a spear through the
one thing they exist to protect,
and the tide is going OUT, Brad,
and it is not coming back in.

A beat. Brad studies him. Then, with the invincible calm of a man who has survived every consequence so far:

BRAD

Okay. Couple things. One --
allegedly. Two --

(unzipping the duffel an
inch; inside, a glint of
small white shapes in a
Ziploc)

-- eighty-six teeth, dude. That's
twenty-five thousand dollars. I
pay Chad, I pay Tyler for the
boat, I'm -- listen to me -- I am
back to ZERO.

(beat; evangelical)

Do you know what zero feels like?
I'm gonna find out Thursday.
AbaloneKing gets here Thursday.

GABRIEL

There isn't going to be a
Thursday.

BRAD

(standing; collecting his
tray and his duffel;
pleasant to the end)

See, that's the energy that keeps
guys like you delivering --

(squints at Gabriel's
lanyard)

-- whatever you deliver. Think
bigger, my guy.

He walks off. Gabriel sits alone at the table. Around him,
one by one -- unnoticed by the lunch crowd, unmistakable
to us -- every SODA FOUNTAIN along the wall stops
mid-pour, and the ice machines fall silent, and in two
hundred cups across the dining commons, the liquid tilts,
very slightly, toward the sea.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

EXT. ANACAPA SHORES -- BLUFFS -- DAWN -- THURSDAY

The wide shot the whole movie has been saving.

The ocean is gone.

Not low tide. GONE. The seabed lies exposed for a mile -- wet, gleaming, ribbed with sand, littered with kelp and stranded fish and a century of lost things: a rowboat, a refrigerator, an anchor chain running out toward a horizon where a thin silver line of sea waits, motionless, like something holding its breath.

No birds. No wind. The silence is total and costs the sound department everything they have.

Along the bluff edge, evenly spaced, facing out: THE POSSESSED. More of them now. Thirty. Fifty. Groundskeepers, adjuncts, a UPS driver, the entire women's water polo team. Water runs from every hairline.

EXT. ANACAPA SHORES -- CENTRAL QUAD -- CONTINUOUS

Students film the empty seabed on their phones. Then, from every pole speaker on campus, flat and mechanical, the EMERGENCY SIRENS begin -- that long Cold War rise-and-fall -- and the phones all shriek in unison:

INSERT -- PHONE: "TSUNAMI WARNING -- THIS IS NOT A DRILL -- MOVE TO HIGH GROUND --"

The quad breaks into a running tide of students flowing inland, and the SIRENS wail on --

INT. GAS STATION BATHROOM -- CONTINUOUS [REALITY]

INSERT: Gary's hand, gripping the edge of the sink so hard the fixture creaks. Over it, muffled through the door, barely audible under the siren-wail that carries across the cut:

MANAGER'S VOICE (O.S.)

(through the door)
Sir, it's been two hours. We're
gonna have to call somebody.

SMASH CUT BACK TO:

**INT. ANACAPA SHORES -- BROOME LIBRARY -- SPECIAL
COLLECTIONS -- CONTINUOUS [THE EPIC]**

Sirens, muffled through the glass. Against the flow of
evacuation, Gabriel shoulders IN through the doors. Ruth
stands at her desk -- not evacuating, not surprised --
with a single file laid out and waiting, as if she has
kept this appointment for thirty years.

RUTH
I pulled it the day you first
walked in. I wanted to be wrong.

She turns the file to face him. TREJO, ELIAS -- 0113.
Intake 1949. Deceased March 1997 -- three months before
the hospital closed.

GABRIEL
The last one.

RUTH
The last watcher on this coast. I
was with him at the end. He
wasn't afraid. He held my hand
and he apologized -- to me -- for
leaving the watch empty. And he
said someone would come back for
it.

(beat)
He said it in English, and then
he said it facing the window, in
a language I've only ever heard
one other place --

GABRIEL
The fountain.

RUTH

The fountain.

She slides a photograph out of the file. Old color print, faded to orange. A visiting room, 1980s. An old man -- Elias, unmistakably -- holding an infant, laughing. Beside him a young woman.

On the back, in ballpoint: "Elias with daughter Marisol & grandson -- visit, Aug '85."

Gabriel looks at the photograph for a very long time. The film does not say his mother's name. The film does not have to. His hand, when he takes the photo, is the hand of a man taking back something that was always his.

RUTH (CONT'D)

(gently)

"You came back."

GABRIEL

(quiet)

I never knew. She never -- nobody
ever told me what he --

RUTH

Nobody ever told anyone anything,
Gabriel. That was the whole
facility. Fifty years of nobody
telling anyone anything.

(beat; nodding at the
window, the sirens, the
vanished sea)

This is what the silence cost.

Gabriel pockets the photograph and heads for the door.
Stops.

GABRIEL

Ruth. High ground.

RUTH

(returning her glasses to
their chain; serene)

Young man, I have worked in this
library for twenty-six years. I
would like to see the wave.

EXT. ANACAPA SHORES -- BLUFF TRAIL -- MINUTES LATER

Gabriel runs the bluff trail against the sirens. Sam's
groundskeeping cart is parked at the overlook, and Sam
stands beside it, scanning the exposed seabed below with
binoculars.

SAM

(without lowering them)

Your boy's down there.

She hands Gabriel the binoculars.

BINOCULAR POV: far out on the glistening seabed, a small
figure with a duffel bag and a five-gallon bucket, picking
his way happily between stranded fish. BRAD. Behind him,
trudging with a second bucket, TYLER.

GABRIEL

You have got to be --

SAM

Whole ocean floor full of abalone
and stranded halibut, and a boy
four thousand dollars in the
hole. Of course he's down there.

Gabriel lowers the binoculars. Looks at the trail down.
Looks at the thin silver line on the horizon.

SAM (CONT'D)

(quietly; not stopping him;
informing him)

When it comes, it comes faster
than a man can run. You know
that.

GABRIEL

(already moving)

He's a kid, Sam.

SAM
(calling after him; the
closest she comes to a
blessing)
So was Elias!

EXT. EXPOSED SEABED -- MINUTES LATER

An alien world. Gabriel runs out across the ribbed sand, past the gasping fish, past the refrigerator, boots sinking, sirens thin and far behind him now. Ahead, Brad has reached the SEA CAVE -- its mouth fully exposed for the first time in ten thousand years, hung with dripping weed, exhaling cold air.

BRAD
(into the cave; delighted;
his voice echoing)
Tyler! TYLER! It's like a Costco
in here!

GABRIEL
(arriving, gasping)
BRAD!

Brad turns. Sees Gabriel. Rolls his eyes with his entire body.

BRAD
Oh my -- dude. Are you following
me? This is a public beach. Well
--
(gesturing at the seabed)
-- it is NOW.

GABRIEL
The water is coming back. All of
it. At once. Look at the horizon,
Brad. Look at it.

Brad looks. The silver line is thicker than it was. He looks back at Gabriel, and for one second -- one full

second, and the film holds it -- something in Brad's face knows. Some animal floor of him understands exactly what he is looking at.

And then, as it has his whole life, the ledger wins.

BRAD

(turning back to the cave)
Five minutes. There's like nine
hundred dollars of abalone in
arm's reach, my guy. Five
minutes.

GABRIEL

There are no minutes!

He grabs Brad's arm. Brad shakes him off -- and then stops, struck by a genuinely warm thought, and turns back, reaching into the duffel:

BRAD

Okay wait -- actually -- you've
been, like, weirdly invested in
my journey. I respect that.
(producing the Ziploc;
holding it out; sincere)
You want a tooth? For real.
Friends and family price. Two
hundred.

The horizon line is a wall now, and it has begun, very faintly, to ROAR.

Gabriel looks at the bag of teeth. At Brad's open, generous, doomed face. And Gabriel -- Gary -- the film lets them be the same man for one beat -- makes the only choice either of them has ever really had:

He offers Brad his hand.

GABRIEL

Come with me. Right now. Leave
the bag.

A beat. Brad looks at the hand. The roar builds. Tyler is already running -- Tyler, blessed with the survival

instincts Brad was born without, is a shrinking figure halfway to the bluffs, buckets abandoned.

BRAD

(with real regret, as if
declining brunch)

I can't leave the bag, man. The
bag is the whole thing.

Gabriel stands there one more second -- then runs. He runs and the film goes with him and does not look back at Brad, and the ROAR rises, and behind everything, under everything, the DRONE returns, enormous now --

EXT. ANACAPA SHORES -- BLUFFS -- CONTINUOUS

Gabriel scrambles up the trail as the light changes -- the whole sky taking on the color of the thing rising behind him. He reaches the top. Sam pulls him over the edge.

And they turn. And they see it. And we don't. Not yet. We stay on their faces -- Sam's, ancient and unsurprised; Gabriel's, wet with -- seawater? sweat? the film has stopped distinguishing -- as the SHADOW of it comes over them.

Along the bluffs, the fifty possessed watchers raise their arms -- not in command. In WELCOME. And they speak, fifty voices and the harmonics under them, one final time, and the words are almost lost under the roar:

THE POSSESSED

(in unison)

Kiy 'alulkoy. The water
remembers.

REVERSE -- AND THE FILM FINALLY SHOWS US THE WAVE:

The full width of the horizon, higher than the bluffs, higher than the bell tower, black-green and veined with foam, and inside its face -- held in the wave, moving with it, uncountable -- DOLPHINS. The entire pod and every pod there has ever been, ten thousand years of them, swimming in the wall of the sea, and the wave gathers over the campus, over the arcades, over the buried foundation of the hydrotherapy annex, and CRESTS --

-- the lip of it curling, this exact frame, the single
most expensive shot in the picture, beginning to descend
--

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. GAS STATION BATHROOM -- REALITY

EXTREME CLOSE-UP, SLOW MOTION: a single BEAD OF SWEAT
gathers at Gary's hairline, swells -- cresting -- and
drops.

It falls.

HARD CUT TO BLACK.

A beat of absolute silence.

Then, in the dark, alone, unaccompanied, unscored:

SOUND: a TOILET FLUSHES.

The full flush. All of it. The tank refill. The little
dying gurgle at the end.

Silence.

END OF FILM.

FADE OUT.